



2024

Nursing Career Compass

Practical Nursing Career Paths
for Students, New Graduates, and Nurses
Who Need a Change

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What is the Career Compass?

Maybe you’re a nursing student, preparing for your NCLEX and looking forward to the future. Maybe you’re working on your MSN, DNP, or PhD while juggling a full-time job. Or maybe you’re working night shifts at the bedside, feeling the sting of burnout, and interested in exploring new opportunities.

Sound familiar? **If so, the Career Compass is for you.** Whether you’re just starting out or looking for a new direction, Elite Learning is here to partner with you on your professional nursing journey. Look inside for a handy guide to several popular career paths for nurses.

RN + Specialty Certifications

What They Do

Registered Nurses (RNs) assess patient conditions, develop and implement nursing care plans, administer medications, perform treatments and procedures, educate patients and families, collaborate with other healthcare professionals, and advocate for patient needs.

Education Requirements

To become an RN, individuals must complete an accredited nursing program, which can lead to either an associate degree in nursing (ADN) or a bachelor's degree in nursing (BSN). ADN programs typically take 2-3 years, while BSN programs usually take 4 years.

Career Opportunities

RNs have a wide range of career options, including bedside nursing, public health nursing, case management, nursing education, and leadership roles.

For nurses fascinated by and passionate about a particular facet of healthcare, RNs also have countless opportunities to pursue specialized care with certifications. Here are just a few.

Average Salary

Mean U.S. hourly salary:

\$42.80

Mean U.S. annual salary:

\$89,010

Certified Wound Care Nurse

Whether they're cleaning injuries in the Emergency Department or educating patients on suture care after surgery, nurses play a pivotal role in wound care.

From skin anatomy to debridement, build vital expertise with the 10-hour intermediate [Certified Wound Care Nurse Exam Prep](#) course, which prepares nurses for the Wound Care Nurse Exam or re-certification.

[EXPLORE COURSE](#)

Oncology Certified Nurse

Nurses are at the crux of care for patients undergoing cancer treatment. An oncology certification empowers nurses to provide the specialized care that cancer patients need to optimize their outcomes.

Prepare for Oncology Certified Nurse (ONC®) renewal with the **Oncology Nurse Re-Certification Course**.

This 30-hour video module recertification course prepares nurses for their Oncology Certification Renewal. Reviewed by the Oncology Nursing Certification Corporation (ONCC), this course is approved for up to 30 recertification points.

[EXPLORE COURSE](#)



Advanced Practice Registered Nurse

Certified Registered Nurse Anesthetists

What They Do

Certified Registered Nurse Anesthetists (CRNAs) administer anesthesia to patients undergoing surgery or other medical procedures. This includes assessing patients before anesthesia, administering anesthesia agents, monitoring patients during procedures, managing pain, and providing post-anesthesia care.

Education Requirements

To become an CRNA, individuals must hold a bachelor's degree in nursing (BSN), a current RN license, a minimum of one year of acute care experience, and successfully complete a nurse anesthesia educational program accredited by the Council on Accreditation of Nurse Anesthesia Educational Programs (COA).

CRNA programs may lead to a master's or Doctor of Nursing Practice (DNP) degree. Certified registered nursing anesthetists need a Master of Science in Nursing (MSN) to practice. However, in a change supported by the American Association of Nurse Anesthetists (AANA), all new CRNAs must hold a doctoral degree to enter the field in 2025.

Average Salary

Mean U.S. hourly salary:

\$98.93

Mean U.S. annual salary:

\$205,770

Career Opportunities

CRNAs primarily work in hospitals, surgical centers, and other healthcare facilities where anesthesia services are required. They may also work independently in some states.



Advanced Practice Registered Nurse Certified Nurse Midwives

What They Do

Certified Nurse Midwives (CNMs) provide prenatal care, attend births, provide postpartum care to mothers and newborns, perform gynecological exams, provide family planning services, and educate patients about reproductive health.

Education Requirements

To become a CNM, individuals must earn at least a master's degree in nursing (MSN) with a focus on nurse-midwifery.

Career Opportunities

CNMs can work in hospitals, birthing centers, clinics, and private practices. They provide care to women throughout the lifespan, including prenatal, labor and delivery, postpartum, and gynecological care.

Average Salary

Mean U.S. hourly salary:

\$58.87

Mean U.S. annual salary:

\$122,450



A nursing degree opens so many doors.

Listen to the inspiring stories of nursing pioneers in our recent CE podcast series:

[Distinguished Careers in Nursing.](#)



Advanced Practice Registered Nurse Certified Nurse Specialists

What They Do

Clinical Nurse Specialists (CNS) are Advanced Practice Registered Nurses with clinical expertise in a specialized area of nursing practice, such as cardiology or pediatrics. CNS engage in the diagnosis and treatment of acute or chronic illness with an emphasis on specialist care for at-risk patients and/or populations. CNS practice extends from wellness to illness and from acute to primary care.

Education Requirements

To become a CNS, individuals must first become an APRN by earning an MSN from an accredited program. They must pass a certification examination in a general area, either adult/gerontology, pediatrics, or neonatal. Following this, most employers will require additional certifications, based on what department you practice in.

Career Opportunities

Clinical nursing specialties can range from cardiology, diabetes, pediatrics, mental health, wound care, emergency department care, among others. Depending on their specialties, they can work in a variety of settings, but most often CNSs work in hospitals. Like all APRNs, they have greater professional autonomy than RNs and can diagnose conditions and prescribe treatments.

Average Salary

Mean U.S. hourly salary:
Depends on specialty

Mean U.S. annual salary:
Depends on specialty



Healthcare is hard, and burnout can hit at any point in your nursing career.

Explore strategies to build resilience with our recent CE podcast

[Boundaries and Burnout: Strategies for Nurses to Maintain Self.](#)

Advanced Practice Registered Nurse Nurse Practitioner

What They Do

Nurse Practitioners (NPs) assess, diagnose, and treat patients with acute and chronic illnesses. They order and interpret diagnostic tests, prescribe medications, provide health counseling, perform procedures within their scope of practice, and collaborate with other healthcare professionals.

Education Requirements

To become an NP, individuals must have a master's degree in nursing (MSN) or a Doctor of Nursing Practice (DNP) degree and specialize in a specific area.

Career Opportunities

NPs can work in various healthcare settings, including primary care clinics, specialty clinics, hospitals, urgent care centers, and community health centers. They can specialize in family practice, pediatrics, adult gerontology, psychiatric-mental health, and other areas.

Average Salary

Mean U.S. hourly salary:

\$59.94

Mean U.S. annual salary:

\$124,680

Preparing for your NP Certification Exam?

Browse study tips, Q&As, practice questions, and test-taking strategies from nursing luminary [Dr. Margaret Fitzgerald](#).



Want to learn more about exciting career opportunities in nursing?

Take a peek behind the curtain in our recent podcast series: [Careers in Nursing: Academia, Leadership, and Practice](#).

What They Do

Nurse Managers oversee the daily operations of their unit or department, including staffing, scheduling, budgeting, and quality improvement initiatives. They provide leadership and support to nursing staff, address patient care issues, collaborate with interdisciplinary teams, and ensure compliance with regulatory standards.



What's behind a healthcare budget? Dive in with Elite's in-depth nurse leadership podcast series: Making Sense of Dollars and Cents: [Budgeting Best Practices](#) and [Staffing Skills for Nurse Leaders](#).

Education Requirements

To become a Nurse Manager, individuals must have a bachelor's degree in nursing (BSN) or a master's degree in nursing, leadership, and/or administration. Many employers prefer candidates with leadership experience, additional healthcare management, or administration education.

Many Nurse Manager positions may require certification in nursing administration. However, some organizations will hire nurses with associate degrees who have shown leadership capabilities.

Career Opportunities

Nurse Managers oversee the daily operations of their unit or department, including staffing, scheduling, budgeting, and quality improvement initiatives. They provide leadership and support to nursing staff, address patient care issues, collaborate with interdisciplinary teams, and ensure compliance with regulatory standards.

Average Salary

Mean U.S. hourly salary:

\$50.48

Mean U.S. annual salary:

\$117,687



Explore the intersection of healthcare and business.

Get an inside look at the ups and downs of day-to-day healthcare operations from an NP's perspective with the [Elite Nurse Practitioner podcast](#)

How to Display Your Nursing Credentials

Nurses often joke about the alphabet soup of credentials that can follow a nurse or advanced practice nurse's name. With all the different licenses, degrees, and certifications available, the growing list of letters can take on a life of its own.

To standardize across the profession, the ANCC lists the preferred order of credentials as follows:

- Highest earned degree
- Licensure
- State designations or requirements
- National certification
- Awards and honors
- Other recognitions

The recommended order starts with the degree, which is a permanent credential and, barring extreme circumstances, cannot be taken away. Following a nurse's degrees are the license and state designations, as these are required to practice.

Professional certifications are sometimes voluntary, as are awards and honors. Additionally, professional certifications could lapse and are more easily separated from the individual than their license, which is why they follow degrees and licensure.





Challenges Facing Today's Nurses

There's no denying it: The pandemic has left deep scars on the healthcare profession. From burnout to understaffing, today's nurses face intense challenges at the bedside and beyond.

We want you to know that you're not alone. Wherever your learning journey takes you, the team of nurses at Elite is here to support you.

Meet your state CE requirements

From men's health to suicide prevention, explore free nurse CE courses to help you meet your state nursing continuing education requirements.

[BROWSE FREE CE FOR NURSES](#)

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Build skills with free webinars

Join industry experts on topics including ostomy care, mental well-being and the gut-brain axis, substance use stigma, and more in our series of free webinars, presented live and on-demand throughout 2024.

[VIEW WEBINAR SCHEDULE](#)

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Expand your expertise with advanced courses

Whether you're an APRN looking for pharmacotherapeutic hours or an RN looking to expand your expertise, browse our **Advanced Practice Pharmacology Collection**, including courses on psychopharmacology, pediatric pharmacology, and more.

[EXPLORE PHARMACOLOGY COURSES](#)



About Elite Learning

For over 20 years, Elite Learning has been dedicated to providing licensed professionals from around the nation with the highest quality continuing education and professional development courses that not only meet their state mandated requirements, but also empower them with the knowledge they need to achieve more in their careers.

Elite Learning

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Sources: [Bureau of Labor Statistics](#), [Indeed.com](#)